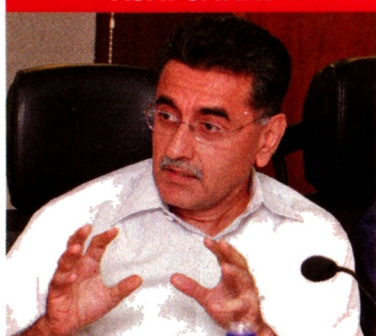




AJAI SAHNI



“The Government prematurely announced operations against the Naxals and destroyed the element of surprise.

The Government has thrown the initiative into the hands of the Maoists.

The Government has taken on the Maoists by reaching into their heartland, forcing them to launch attacks in other states.

There is a tremendous wastage of existing capacity and even the available police capacity is not being used.

The Centre can learn from Andhra Pradesh which fought the Naxals by retraining and re-deploying its forces.”

include strengthening of governance in affected areas. We should start by not making Naxal-affected areas a punishment posting but by sending the right people; not by sending money to be looted by politicians and bureaucrats but ensuring that something is done. But if we keep on ignoring as we have done in the past, the situation will get out of hands.

Kiran Bedi: I had a part in drafting the Model Police Act of 2006, submitted to the government on October 30, 2006, and chaired by Soli Sorabjee. One suggestion was the creation of special security zones (SSZ). I am looking at the SSZ of the six affected states. If the security of an area is threatened by insurgency, terrorism or militant activities, the Union Government may with the concurrence of the state government declare such an area as a SSZ. Any such notification will be placed before the appropriate legislature for ratification within six months from the date of issue or the first sitting of the legislature, provided that the period of notification shall not exceed two years unless it is ratified by the Parliament with the concurrence of the state legislature. It also said that the state government shall create an appropriate police structure and a suitable command control and response system for such a zone. The states to ensure co-ordinated functioning of different wings of the administration, should set up in each security zone suitable administrative structures which will integrate administration and development measures with police response. The DGP shall, with the concurrence of the state government, issue orders laying down standard proceedings. We have not done all this.

We need to bring states together to become a security development zone under a single command structure. Why is Andhra safe today? Andhra has the Greyhounds. You pressure the Naxals here, they run elsewhere. Its happening in West Bengal. Why can't the country work together? Chidambaram should look at this. This will be being pro-active and this is what the leadership needs to do. Look at the police from West

Bengal, they hardly had a roof on their heads. Newspaper photos showed a policeman in a lungi there. Our policemen are not prepared for this zone at all. Why are they being sent there as cannon fodder.

You cannot wait for new recruitment from the jungle warfare schools. Create a force comprising young retired army men for the next ten years. Call it an SSZ force. To me this is the real political challenge. If Chidambaram succeeds in putting this, he has proved himself as the home minister of India, otherwise not. **V.K. Datta:** Our response to the Naxal problem is knee-jerk. The threat emanates from Nepal and comes all the way to the centre of India. You have to go in and dominate that area so completely that the Maoists don't return. You cannot just go there for an operation and come back. You need to have a permanent presence. Conduct development activities in the area, run a hearts and minds campaign, improve the socio-economic infrastructure and provide education but do not go in like an army of occupation.

Ajai Sahni: The Government has taken on the Maoists by threatening to reach into their heartland and has forced them into taking pre-emptive action in other states. We talk and can't do. The Naxals talk and do. The Government prematurely announced operations against the Naxals even before the security apparatus was in place. They destroyed the element of surprise and are now running around trying to deal with the violence the Naxals promised to unleash in their June document in which they said the Centre lacked the capacity to operate against them across the country. The Government has thrown the initiative into the hand of the Maoists. In the short-term, capacities have to be re-oriented. Andhra Pradesh had the lowest police-population ratio but fought the Naxals by retraining, re-orienting and re-deploying its forces. This is what the Central paramilitary forces are not doing.

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